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Slew of new dSLRs

Even as Canon introduced the EOS 1100D and EOS 600D this month, Nikon quietly slipped in the D5100

recess with its dimpled contours is actually grippy. We don't like the viewfinder though, it is an electronic type and feels like a cheap add-on – ditch it Canon.

Of the two Fujifilm's, the Finepix S3300 is a lot cheaper, in fact, it plays the same game at nearly half the cost of the other two cameras. Unlike its costlier sibling, the Fujifilm HS20 EXR, it won't record videos at 1080p, and neither does it have as good a build. The two Fujifilm cameras have the same silhouette – they have exaggerated grip portions, that are deep without being substantial and while this allows your fingers to curl inwards making for a secure grip, it's not as substantial as the grip on a dSLR. Right, it wasn't meant to be...What we didn't like, was the fact that the S3300 feels like a cheaper cousin to the HS20 EXR – from the body surface, to the lens.

On topic of lens the Fujifilm HS20 EXR features manual zoom and while we dig the extra bit of control, we question its need, especially given it needs variable pressure to use and isn't as smooth as we'd like. The inner barrel of the lens is metal however, unlike Canon that uses a plastic barrel on the SX30IS. There's a nice large mode dial set into the top at an attractive angle, while the dial next to it allows changing settings in conjunction with activating a function. The LCD articulates but unlike the hinge cum twist mechanism used by Canon, this is a 2-way hinge built into the camera body. As a result the LCD cannot orient sideways i.e. horizontally, but only vertically. Functions like ISO and aperture have dedicated buttons and once selected, the dial atop can change the corresponding setting – for the most this setup works pretty well.

There is an electronic view-

finder provided on the HS20 EXR, but its pretty archaic, and you're better off using the LCD. The video record button is small and recessed and therefore not intuitive to use, but it is located conveniently. The SD card slot is built into the side and the mechanism similar to dSLRs like the Nikon D7000. Four AA batteries are used – and these make the camera heavy, we'd have loved a Li-ion battery. The focus ring on the lens is set back into the body, though thankfully usability doesn't suffer much on this account.

The S3300 loses on the settings dial on the top and just has a mode dial with no rear dial. As a result, settings are a bit tougher to change. We also don't like the hard joypad buttons and the menu button set within the joypad. This one features a zoom ring, and we figure we can live without the manual zoom, which becomes impractical when dealing with larger focal ranges. Settings are abundant although making these changes is a little more tedious. The lens features a maximum aperture of f3.1, which is not much considering cameras like the SX30IS offer an aperture of f2.7 and this makes quite a difference in terms of light gathering.

Performance

The Canon SX30 IS offers better still image quality than both Fujifilm cameras. The output is a little soft, but there's a fair bit of detail available, at least the image doesn't seem to suffer from over-much noise, unlike the output from the Fujifilm cameras, that seem plagued with the same. The SX30 IS produces neutral images, and though we'd like a little more life to the highlighting, one cannot argue that Canon is giving you about as close to a realistic experience as possible.

The S3300 offered highlights, but these seem clipped. Orange is a little warmer than we'd like, and there is a noticeable lack of detail in the reds, the dynamic range of this sensor seems mediocre. The Fujifilm HS20 EXR displays artificial looking grain-like artefacts on some fruit, and once again, highlighting is missing, even the SX30 IS that we didn't think was great bested it by a fair margin.

So why did the HS20 EXR get a marginally higher score than the SX30 IS? Well, both Fujifilm cameras do ISO 3200, and while the output is poor, at least the setting is available and they get a few point apiece for "participating". Also the HS20 EXR gets a decent score for 1080p recording, whereas the SX30 IS gets a rounded off zero, having missed this feature. If you're after the better camera, the SX30 IS is your best bet, and for low light, blows both Fujifilm cameras out of the water.

Our Best Buy however, is the Fujifilm S3300, given that you can buy nearly two of them for a single Canon SX30 IS and the performance while nothing close to Canon, is not exactly 50 per cent worse.

PROSUMER COMPACTS QUALITY MEETS MANUAL CONTROL

The above tag about sums up these cameras – they're not cheap, but neither is an iPhone, a GTX 580 or even a Ninja 250R. However, they are designed with a niche audience in mind – the kind of person who is interested in taking good quality photos, and knows enough about photography to care about manual control, and not just a full manual mode, but a set of buttons, dials and controls that allow him to really change settings quickly, intuitively and effectively. After all, to discerning clickers, it is all

about the shot, and a good camera is a given. Sadly, there's no substitute for lots of dials and buttons, and while we reviewers praise dSLRs and their ilk for having a lot of well laid out manual controls, our hearts yearn for a better system. Don't feel our pain? Spend a year mastering controls and getting good shots on a Canon EOS 7D, and then promptly try taking quick shots in manual mode on a Nikon D300s and you'll get our drift.

All three cameras here are quite special. They're compact, but they borrow several tricks used in dSLRs to make their user more at home and provide more controls to each finger, just as long as your fingers are nimble, you won't have any issues. But that's not all – they also provide better sensors, better electronics to better control noise, and better-built bodies with better and more ergonomic designs.

Features

There's a bag full of features to be found here. The Nikon P7000 and Canon G12 look suspiciously alike. They're both powerful compacts, designed with the intent of giving clickers a more serious body, without the hassles of changing lenses and the extra weight and bulk of a dSLR. Both bodies are bristling with dials – they both feature as many as five. Finally we see a Nikon with the variable pressure zoom although Canon's system works better. The P7000 has an exposure compensation dial on the top of the camera, and a scene dial next to it. However, neither are usable with one thumb. On the top of the left side is another dial and this one allows quick access to a number of settings – quality, ISO setting and white balancing to name a few. Select a function and click the inset button and it's activated to be changed via spinning the rear